has been overlooked. It is true that outside Punjab there were broader mobilizations taking place across India at this time. These were principally in the name of swadeshi/swaraj, the Gandhian idea of ‘self-sufficiency’ that was aimed at wresting control of indigenous industries, given that the British relied on them for their economic power. [15] However, these mobilizations should not be allowed to obscure the revolt from indigenous political organizations. Bhagat Singh’s family played a major role in these. So much so that by the time that Bhagat Singh was born his family had already laid the foundations for his revolutionary activities, as we shall see in the next chapter.

To separate Bhagat Singh’s story from that of his family is to overlook precisely how and why he rose to the national scene as he did. This is all too revealingly shown in the 1917 work of James Campbell Ker. He was the personal assistant to the director of criminal intelligence from 1907 to 1913 and therefore one of the senior officers of the Home Department of the British Indian Government. ‘In this capacity’, according to Jamna Das Akhtar, ‘he had direct access to the highly confidential documents relating to the political activities that had become [a] source of embarrassment to the British rulers’. [16] He puts the role of Bhagat Singh’s family so high in the revolutionary moment of Punjab that, when referring to the ‘flood of seditious literature in the form of books and pamphlets in the vernacular’ in the province, he states ‘two agencies were mainly responsible for their production’, and of these, ‘the second [was] by Ajit Singh, the deportee, his two brothers, Kishen Singh and Sowaran Singh’. [17]